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How the Meta Settlement Silences Youth Activism

Since its integration into our digital world, social media has played a pivotal role in youth organizing and social mobilization. Yet, people's access to these platforms is increasingly coming under threat from courts and legislatures under the guise of protecting young people online—presenting a significant hindrance to youth organizing.

In a major recent example, Meta [settled in a lawsuit](#) with 52 states and territories regarding the use of Instagram and Facebook by young people. The settlement will require Meta, and pressure other non-Meta owned platforms like TikTok and YouTube, to embed age gating practices into

every product while also requiring restrictions on the accounts of people under-18, such as a two-hour daily time limit and content restrictions.

Youth Power on Social Media

Young people have been using social media for political advocacy and community organizing for more than a decade. From organizing [protests speaking out against police brutality](#), to organizing [nationwide school walkouts](#) demanding safety in schools from gun violence, and [striking to demand](#) lawmakers take action to protect the climate, social media has become an instrumental tool for youth to both speak out and connect with other young activists.

Instagram has [become especially useful](#) for activism online by young people. The features on the app make it a helpful tool for being able to efficiently and quickly spread awareness, which is especially important when people need to share real-time information. For example, 17-year-old [Darnella Frazier's video on Facebook](#) showed the world the murder of George Floyd.

The impact of youth activism online is also evident on non-Meta owned platforms, with services like TikTok and YouTube being [particularly](#) prevalent [spaces](#) for young people to share their stories, build movements, and amplify collective engagement.

However, in a digital world operating under the settlement's new guidelines, young people risk not being able to read crucial news due to the content being labeled as "age-inappropriate," which has [already happened for teenagers in Australia](#) under its social media ban.

A two-hour daily time limit and a block on Meta's apps between midnight and 6am leaves little room for young activists to organize rapid response efforts. Being unable to see likes on a post will make it difficult to gauge the effectiveness of their campaigns.

Add to this [what we already know](#) about Meta's content policies which claim to "protect children" and keep sites "family-friendly" but instead label content like [LGBTQ+ content](#) as "adult" or "harmful," youth will be left with no choice in what content they see once the 'age-appropriate' content filter is turned on by default. One [recent report](#) noted that Meta had hidden posts that reference LGBTQ+ hashtags like #lesbian, #bisexual, #gay, #trans, and #queer for users with the sensitive content filter on. This would specifically curtail the efforts of young activists doing work on comprehensive sex education.

Global Trends

Measures like this are being discussed across the globe, but not all courts have taken such a short-sighted approach. In August, the French Constitutional Council [got a lot right](#) in its [decision](#) to strike down the country's legislation banning under-15s from social media for infringing free expression and communication for everyone online, not just young people.

The French Court also called attention to its infringement on privacy as the legislation would have forced people of all ages to hand over [government IDs](#), [face scans](#), and [other sensitive information](#) to prove their age and access online content.

Requiring this much data from users puts activists in danger of [even more surveillance](#). Meta has already previously complied with [demands from law enforcement to hand over the messages](#) of users. The amount of personal information that will be logged and that could be demanded via a warrant from police to stifle or investigate activists' actions or plans could cause a chilling effect, forcing advocates to pause or terminate their work.

This is egregious because these systems misidentify or lock out [people of color](#), [people with disabilities](#), and [trans or gender-nonconforming](#) individuals whose IDs may not match their chosen name or align with what the system expects them to look like upon verification. And it's often these communities that benefit from online organizing the most, especially for [marginalized youth](#) as social media can often be the only place to organize and build community.

What Young People Deserve

[The settlement generates headlines](#), but it will not solve the core problem. Instead of tackling Meta's surveillance capitalism business model that turns all online content into potential profit and centers lining the company's pockets over protecting the speech and privacy of users, this settlement gives the tech giant an opportunity to carve out a new digital world that prioritizes its own needs, not those of young people.

As we've been [calling attention](#) to in other contexts, this will force young people into digital isolation—curtailing vital access to [news](#) and [resources](#) for health and development. It also completely ignores the [calls of](#)

[youths themselves who favor digital literacy](#) and education over surveillance and government control.

Young people deserve a better internet than one regulated through panic. They deserve better than the government or Big Tech getting to decide how they use social media and what they can or cannot be exposed to or learn about. They deserve better than having their right to free expression minimized. This must not be lost in the pursuit of building a better and safer online ecosystem and environment.

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